

KF16 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23-24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

This is KF Confession 4:

We judged ourselves and others with contempt and felt justified in our wrath.

I had an interesting opportunity to judge myself and others with contempt and wrath. I had gone out of the house in an unfamiliar town without my keys or phone. When I returned, no one was at home and I was locked out. A KF meeting was due to start in thirty minutes, and I really needed to be in the house and at my computer.

I sat on the doorstep lamenting my fate and going into self-hate for forgetting phones and keys, because I should not, according to my Idol Self, forget phones and keys. Then I remembered my KF training. I used my mindfulness skills to manage my self-hate and got busy with WAA! W-A-A: Words, Attitude, Action. I used my words to pray. I changed my attitude to dismiss shame, and then I was able to creatively open my mind. I took action by boldly looking for a key hidden outside even though I knew that my friends did not leave keys outside. My first stop was the traditional front door mat and, very surprisingly, there under the mat was a key. I was able to get into the house and join the Karis Fellowships meeting on time. The mystery of this story is that my friend said that she had not left the key there. The best part of the story is that my paroxysm of self-hate and self-contempt was not allowed to muddy my prayers or my attitude. Having mercy on myself opened my mind to the possibility of taking oriented action. I was able to find the way that God in His mercy had prepared for me.

Let's continue with the **Mercy Meditation**.¹

Assume a meditation posture and breathe for one minute. Settle into being present and aware. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Draw your mind away from the events of the day, from the past or the future, and from others. Focus on what is happening inside your own skin. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

In this lesson, we will reflect for thirty seconds on three questions. However, when practicing this exercise on your own, you might reflect for one minute. If it works better for you, jot down your thoughts as soon as they come to mind. Sometimes our thoughts get lost if we don't catch them on the spot.

Let's begin our training.

1. In what areas am I most critical of myself? (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)

Pause. Take thirty seconds to jot down what came to mind. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. For what do I need to forgive myself? (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)

Pause, and if you haven't done so already, take thirty seconds to jot down your thoughts. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

3. How do I treat myself when I make a mistake? (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)

Pause, and if you wish, write for thirty seconds. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now experiment with bringing compassion to yourself in some way. For example, call to mind someone who loves you just as you are. This might be someone divine, like God or Jesus, or perhaps someone mortal and human. You might call to mind one of God's other creatures. *(Pause)* Imagine seeing yourself through their eyes. You might give yourself an appreciative hug. *(Pause)* However you choose to bring compassion to yourself, just observe and rest for one minute. Practice letting go of judgment and breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

And pause.

Our hymn for this confession is *When I Survey the Wondrous Cross*.

Forbid it, Lord, that I should boast,
Save in the death of Christ my God!
All the vain things that charm me most,
I sacrifice them to His love.²

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

Let's return to our **Shoulds Worksheet**.

This month we are exploring KF Confession 4:

We judged ourselves and others with contempt and felt justified in our wrath.

We cannot give up our legal systems unless we are willing to give up our search for the *Glory of Me!* or, as Karen Horney puts it, the commitment to actualize the idealized self. This idealized self is an idol that we have manufactured to replace God. When we give up pursuing the Idol's dreams, we can give up the

legal systems that drive us to actualize our Idol. Becoming aware of our legal systems is a positive thing. These systems are flags that signal Idol worship. You can rejoice in the truth of discovering a legal system because it exposes your Idol. Until you recognize your legal systems, you will continue your pursuit of the *Glory of Me!* That's why identifying your legal systems is the first step toward freeing yourself from the Idol and reinvesting in your True Self—the self that lives for the glory of God.

Part 3 of the Shoulds Worksheet: Recovery

This section is divided into eight steps.

1. Recognize the judgment.

Our first step is to look back at the **Two Paths Flowchart**. We have felt fear and have taken the path of judgment. We have decided that a situation is good or bad. Perhaps at this stage you are wondering: *How do I take the path of love?* The **Shoulds Worksheet** helps you learn how to do that, but don't forget that, as a neurotic, you will be tempted to think that knowing something is the same as practicing. Let's get real. Knowing is NOT the same as practicing. You might read a book that teaches the art of skiing, but until you go up the mountain, you will not learn to ski. You cannot learn until you are willing to fall down, get up, fall down, get up, fall down, and get up again. In the process of learning, you will have to patiently endure and overcome lots of fears, failures, and frustrations. It will take time and resources, but if you want to be able to ski, you will commit to spending that time and those resources. You will be willing to fall down and get up over and over again.

When Jesus said that we must become like little children if we are to enter the kingdom of heaven, He may have been talking about the quality of endurance.³ Perhaps what He meant is that, like a toddler, we need to be willing to get up, fall down, and get up again—and to do that repeatedly—until we can walk. Toddlers have courageous, single-minded endurance; they reach their goals through a great deal of effort. Our goal is to be oriented and live a glorious life in the kingdom of God. In order to reach that goal, we need endurance, and we also need the courage to fall down and get up over and over again.

I am emphasizing this teaching about the Judgment Path because you have to know what that path feels like in order to know that you are taking it. When you can identify the characteristics of the Judgment Path, you will be able to recognize that you have chosen it. Through KF training, you are learning that you can, and do, create outcomes. You may now desire healthy outcomes so much that you are willing to work hard and learn to take the Believe It Path. With courageous, single-minded endurance and a great deal of effort, you may now be willing to fall down and get up over and over again until you learn to consistently choose the path of love.

There are many lists of healthy outcomes in the Bible.⁴ These are what we use to measure our progress. You can begin with the **Love or Pride?** list, which is based on First Corinthians, chapter 13. You might think that you are incapable of developing the qualities in these lists. That is not true. You can learn, but it takes training. It takes time and effort. It takes getting up, falling down, and getting up again.

Remember. *Train hard. Fight easy. (Repeat)*

2. Identify the fear

If you cannot perform perfectly, what do you fear? Your idol is supported by your pride system and

your search for an idealized glory. What area of your pride would be hurt if you could not perform perfectly according to your Idol's standards? What aspect of the Idol's dream of glory would be lost? It hurts our pride when we cannot control other people or perfectly manage every area of our lives, when our plans don't work out, or when an imagined future that we have judged as good is snatched away from us. Hurt pride can stop you in your tracks; you become frozen and fierce. You are then unable to move forward and be creative because you are afraid of experiencing more hurt pride. This is how pride interferes with your real potential. I used to feel that at any moment the rug would be pulled out from under me. Even worse, I felt that God was doing the pulling. I constantly found myself attaching to outcomes that I judged as good, and feeling so much hurt and rage when God or others did not agree with me.

3. Stick to the facts

Now that you have recognized the judgment and identified the fear, describe the situation as a simple sequence of events. This skill is the foundation of the Believe It Path. Here is an example: *I went on a trip. I had plans. Someone got sick. I was not able to follow through with my plans. The End.* Oh my! The Believe It Path doesn't sound very dramatic or sensational, does it? It just *is*. We can't write a soap opera or a country western song about the Believe It Path—it's too boring! The Believe It Path gives us nothing to whisper about or to yell at others about. The Judgment Path, on the other hand, leads to conflict, and conflict is the essence of drama. Drama makes our Idol Self feel alive. Feeling alive is very important when you are not alive.

4. Make a decision: Are you ready to let go of the judgment?

When I am coaching someone, I will eventually get to the question: *Are you done with that? (Repeat)* You have a choice. You have the power to say yes or no. I am not asking if you feel like you are done or if you wonder if you are done. I am asking if you choose to be done. There is a simple answer: yes or no. You don't have to be done. You can continue to walk in judgment and pursue your own glory, but you will have to accept that such a choice will inevitably produce misoriented outcomes. When, on the other hand, you choose to be done with your judgments, you finally give yourself permission to change.

5. Consider your progress: What have you learned?

Try to write a few sentences about what you have learned by doing this worksheet. You may have been able to identify a judgment, or you may have recognized a pattern of thought or behavior. You may have learned that you really want to keep repeating this pattern, or perhaps you have learned that you really want to break it. You may simply be thankful.

6. Take action: Talk to God

You are now in touch with the reality of your own business and can make different choices. You have been using words to describe what the Believe It Path looks like for you. Perhaps your attitude has changed. Now is the time to take positive action, and your first positive action is a prayer of confession. Don't try to take this step without doing the first part of the worksheet because you will not get the same result. I call the process of using words, changing your attitude, and taking action W-A-A, or Words-Attitude-Action. By doing the worksheet, you have identified the real problem and have exposed your Idol's story. You are now in touch with the reality of your own business and can make different choices.

7. Integrate

Your body may need some help orienting to the work you have done, so in this section I suggest a

number of different ways to help your body process your work. You can find instructions for using these methods under **Toolbox** on the KF website and, also, at [Alison's tapping and TAT videos](#).

8. Celebrate

We are all learning from each other in this training process, so I hope that you will share what you have learned with your KF community.

You don't have to wait until after an event to do a **Shoulds Worksheet**. This is quite important. You can do a worksheet before you are in a situation that you know will trigger your Idol's shoulds and self-hate. A preemptive worksheet can help you calm your body and forestall judgments and reactions. Also, by working through an upcoming situation on a worksheet, you might find it easier to stand in that situation, oriented in peace.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord, encourage me to do the work of my own healing. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

If you have your Bible with you, turn to the Gospel of Matthew, chapter 7.

As we have said before, legal systems do not foster gratitude. When we expect people to act in a certain way, they can do no more than meet our expectations. When they do manage to comply, we feel no real gratitude for their efforts. We only experience a brief respite from our fear of not being in control. If people only approximate our expectations, there are no points in their favor. They have failed to fulfill all the requirements of our imagined standards and, therefore, deserve our wrath. If, on the other hand, they do meet our expectations, they are not allowed to feel that they have given us a gift of any kind. They are only allowed to feel that they have escaped our wrath for a moment. Laws of shoulds and claims perpetuate contempt, ingratitude, fear, wrath, and resentment, not only toward others but toward ourselves.

I remember when I first learned that love does not insist on its own way or seek its own.⁵ I had just returned from the mission field and was full of idealistic shoulds and claims. For me, ministry meant making everyone—everywhere—be what I wanted them to be. Then I came to understand that love does not insist on its own way, and I felt so helpless. I thought, "If I pursue love, how will I get people to do what I want? How will anything ever get done?"—and, of course, I had virtue stories about why my way of doing things was so important and necessary. I knew, however, that my virtue stories were not helping me learn how to live this powerful life of love and access the many benefits promised to those who choose it. The only way to find out what those promises could mean for me was to trust and follow God's guidance, which, unfortunately for my Idol Self, required that I give up my own way of doing things. As I began the difficult process of learning to love by experiment and obedience, I immediately saw what marvelous benefits the path of love could offer—benefits of peace, efficiency, harmony, and, surprisingly, authority.

Jesus taught us that if we insist on our own way, seeking the fulfillment of our shoulds, we will never experience our true glory.⁶ After several years of exploration, I began to learn how to exchange my personal law of shoulds and claims for oriented, healthy desires. I learned not to insist on my own way but to meet my needs and attain my wants by asking, seeking, and knocking. This is what Jesus Himself taught us to do in **Matthew 7:7–8**. Let's listen to these verses in my translation:

⁷Ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and it will be opened to you. ⁸This is how it works: the asking one receives, the seeking one finds, and to the one who is knocking, it will be opened.

Take a deep breath.

You might like to read the whole chapter and notice how the Bible supports what we teach in Karis Fellowships. You can choose to move away from trying to impose your legal systems of shoulds and claims and train for the karis alternative, which, as Jesus taught us, is to ask, seek, and knock. I am sorry to say this, but God and the Creation do not just show up to support you. God and the Creation cannot meet you in your Idol Self. You must go where God and the Creation are. They are in reality, in the real evidence of life, and not in your illusions and stories.

In the passage for this lesson, Jesus encourages us to stop wasting energy trying to impose our shoulds and claims; instead, He invites us to learn the process of asking, seeking, and knocking. Asking, seeking, and knocking are all qualities of a person. If you are the kind of person who keeps asking, the kind of person who keeps seeking, and the kind of person who keeps knocking on a regular basis, then Jesus is talking about you. If you are not the kind of person who regularly and consistently asks, seeks, and knocks, then you probably are not experiencing the gifts that God has for you. Hopefully, in Karis Fellowships, you are learning to become the kind of person who regularly asks, seeks, and knocks—someone who has the attitude of an explorer and can fall down and get up over and over again. Let's take a look at what each of these steps involves.

Asking is Words

Ask for help. Start by learning to ask questions so that you can understand the situation. Tell God and others what is going on inside your skin. Do you know that other people can't read your mind? It is an infantile claim to expect them to do so. Toddlers learn to use their words, and so can you. Telling others what is going on inside you is not a license to impose your demands on others and the world, nor is it an opportunity to voice your opinions about what they should or should not do to accommodate you. When you ask, you have an opportunity to practice expressing your own reality moderately. If you want God or anyone else to listen to you, you will have to learn moderation. Moderate expression is evidence that you have done your own work and attended to your own business. When you do not express yourself moderately, you are indulging your Idol Self. God will not support that, and neither should anyone else. If you do your KF work, you will be able to use words to speak your reality moderately and communicate what you would prefer, without wrath or fear. That doesn't mean that your desires, your hopes, and the way you express yourself is good or perfect; it simply means you have become real. In the KF sharing time, you learn to speak and listen without judging or evaluating yourself or others. To ask is simply to say in a moderate manner what is true about yourself.

Seeking is Attitude

Open your mind, open your eyes, and open your ears, or as James puts it, "Be quick to hear, slow to speak, and slow to wrath."⁷ When you stop feeling entitled to having your needs and illusions magically

accommodated, you can start looking at what is real. When our seeking is motivated by the True Self, we are open to what we can learn about ourselves, about others, about God, and about our environment. We are not attached to an outcome that we, in our omniscient and self-righteous judgment, have deemed to be right or good. Seeking is a journey, and it opens up the possibilities of unforeseen discoveries and delightful surprises.

You might ask: *If I am to seek, how do I know what to seek?* That is a great question. When we are looking for something in our house, we will recognize it when we see it, but when looking for something in our lives, it is not so simple. This is why asking, or using words, is the essential first step. When we ask, we are preparing ourselves to recognize the answer. Asking helps us know what we really want. In KF, we are seeking the qualities of the True Self. You will find a list of these qualities in Peter's second letter.⁸ This list is, in essence, an exciting distillation of our true nature in Christ. You also have the list **Love or Pride?**, and we have learned about the characteristics of the Fruit, or Harvest, of the Spirit.⁹ You are seeking to produce the Fruit of the Spirit, which manifests through your life the attributes of love—and if you make love your destination, you will discover other very valuable things along the way, like your True Self.

Knocking is Action

Explore an oriented action and see what happens. When you find a possible path, use your courage and endurance to keep knocking on the door of the not-knowing or, as I did, to keep looking for the key. You really have to give up the idea that you already know what should be behind that door. That is a set-up for hurt pride. When you are focused on what should be behind the door, you narrow your vision to see only what you have already imagined. This is called attachment. It leads to disappointment and to missing the gifts that God has for you. Certainly, the process of exploration won't be easy. In fact, many of us will refuse to knock, or take action, because we fear hurt pride. Our weaknesses or strengths may be exposed, and inevitably things will not live up to our glorious idealized dreams. With training, however, and oriented effort, you can go into the not-knowing and knock in the face of your fears. Something will open to you—something that develops your endurance and courage. A door in your mind may open, or a door to your future may open. It's really the same thing. Through the adventure of knocking, the True Self is trained to fulfill its real glory and power. It grows in endurance and courage and experiences real gratitude.

We often forget that the solutions to our problems are not a matter of just asking. We are so familiar with the acronym A-S-K for Ask, Seek, and Knock that we forget that oriented results come from a three-step process. Our Idol remembers only the easy part—*"Ask and you shall receive"*—so when we have asked, we think our work is done and expect God to do the rest. But remember that there's another way to think about this three-step process: W-A-A or *Words-Attitude-Action*. (*Repeat*)

When confronted with unwanted events, a young friend of ours used to express his feelings like this: "I just wanna say 'Waa!'" It was his general cry to God and to the Creation, and he was pretending to be an infant crying to be taken care of. In this lesson, we are talking about another kind of "Waa!"—W-A-A, which stands for Words, Attitude, Action. Unwanted events are times when God, like an excellent mother, wants to nurture us and, also, train us to nurture ourselves. W-A-A is a call to nurture ourselves by doing something about our discomfort. It is also a call to exercise the self-discipline that an excellent father would teach us. Don't just cry "Waa!" like an immature child or act like a victim whining to the universe and blaming self, circumstances, God, or others. Instead you can think: WAA!—Words, Attitude, Action. This process does not lead to effortless superiority. You have to work to get what you want.

Use moderate words to ask so that you and others can understand what you want. This might be difficult for self-effacing types because they find it hard to ask for anything, but it can be done! Seek with an open

attitude, without judgment, looking for something real that will be revealed. Seeking with an open attitude might be especially difficult for mastery types. Knock, because only action produces re-action—and if you want to make something oriented happen, you have to take oriented action. Resigned types might find taking action particularly hard. We don't just sit around and indulge our feelings, nor do we follow distracting rabbit trails. We refuse to hold others, including God, responsible for our business. Instead, we actively look for a key under the doormat.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Holy Spirit, remind me to use Words, Attitude, Action. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider an area of your life where you could be asking, seeking, and knocking—where you need to use Words, Attitude, Action. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few phrases that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider an area of your life where you could use your words, seek with an open attitude, and take oriented action*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. *(Pause)* With compassion, recognize whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow your experience to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to judge or push away thoughts and feelings or to make up a virtue story. We often flush thoughts or feelings from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. Observe whatever tension you might be feeling as you *consider an area of your life where you could use your words, seek with an open attitude, and take oriented action*. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. You might use a long exhaling breath as you observe your experience. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider this area of your life where you might use Words, Attitude, Action*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can listen and observe. You might notice how your body responds to the fear of hurt pride or to feelings of anxiety, resistance, or even fatigue. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to respectfully observe those

uncomfortable sensations. Breathe, and help your body process with a long exhaling breath or with the Dragon Breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this area of your life where you might use Words, Attitude, Action*. Do you feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* What do you believe when you consider this area of your life? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of what others might do or think, or are you afraid of something in yourself? Perhaps you fear losing your idealized dreams. Observe your responses as just information, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat to yourself the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore an area that might hurt your neurotic pride.
- Welcome the Holy Spirit of truth, who is eager to train you as you use Words, Attitude, Action.
- Welcome your present reality and all the progress you have made so far.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.¹⁰

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I use Words, Attitude, Action, I let go of the longing for power and control.
- As I use Words, Attitude, Action, I let go of the longing for affection and self-admiration.
- As I use Words, Attitude, Action, I let go of the longing for comfort and security.
- As I use Words, Attitude, Action, I let go of the longing for perfection. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank you for this time to heal and train together. Hold us in the power of this redirected energy as You guide us to our real glory and mission. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ www.livingmindfully.org. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.

² *When I Survey the Wondrous Cross* by Isaac Watts (1674–1748), youtu.be/U-hz6L6LAug.

³ Matt. 18:3.

⁴ 2 Pet. 1:5–11, 1 Cor. 13:1–13, Rom. 5:3–5, Gal. 5:16–26.

⁵ 1 Cor. 13:5.

⁶ Matt. 10:38–40.

⁷ James 1:19.

⁸ 2 Pet. 1:5–11.

⁹ 1 Cor. 13:1–13, Gal. 5:16–26.

¹⁰ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.